

Dhoom, *Tiger Zinda Hai*, etc., in Tamil- and Telugu-dubbed versions. More Hindi film studios need to do it with more consistency,” he adds.

Sanjay Mehta, Proprietor of Bobby Enterprises and distributor of Delhi, UP and east Punjab circuits, explains what has gone wrong. “Hindi films have lost out on the connection with the masses. They were concentrating more on films which were metro-centric, or for the overseas market, because multiplexes bring in more money. Multiplex ticket prices are much higher than at single-screen cinemas. That’s the gap filled in by regional films,” he says.

Mehta is hopeful that upcoming films like *Brahmāstra*, *Laal Singh Chaddha*, *Raksha Bandhan*, and *Pathaan*, etc., will do well at the box office. “Bollywood now has a better line-up than Covid times, but Hindi films still need to pull up their socks and improve. Special effects of *Brahmāstra* can be compared to *Baahubali* or *RRR*. The North has realised that they need to spend more on quality,” he adds.

Another reason why experts believe Bollywood is ailing, is because of the content. “Historically, Bollywood films have seen decent collections even when the content has been weak given the strong fan following of superstars. That seems to have changed, with content being the primary driver now. Most movies released in the last two-three quarters have gotten mixed to negative critic reviews, indicating that weak content is the primary factor for the poor performance,” says a recent research report by Emkay Global, which tracks the space.

Bhansali Productions CEO Purna Singh agrees that content needs to be the king. Her latest production, *Gan-gubai Kathiawadi*, made ₹155.5 crore at the box office, nearly half of the ₹400 crore her last Hindi film *Padmaavat* earned, according to Sacnilk. “We would have gotten 3-4x more had it not been for the pandemic. The idea of a star has changed. Now the ‘idea’ is the star. You can’t show somebody’s face



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BHUSHAN KUMAR
CHAIRMAN AND MD,
T-SERIES



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PRERNA SINGH
CEO, BHANSALI
PRODUCTIONS

and expect a hit,” she says.

While there have been some recent hits from Bollywood, there’s quite a gap between the collections of the Hindi-dubbed versions of south Indian films and Bollywood movies, film trade analyst Komal Nahta says. “Bollywood will have to produce 10-12 really good films (and cross the ₹100-crore revenue mark for medium-budget films, and the ₹200-300 crore revenue mark for bigger budget films) in the remaining months of the year, to close the gap with what Hindi-dubbed versions of the south Indian films have been collecting,” he says.

Nahta, however, is wary of writing off Bollywood. “The success ratio of Bollywood has always been 18-20 per cent every year,” he says.

PVR Pictures CEO Kamal Gianchandani, too, sees this as nothing but a rough patch. “The reason why it’s getting accentuated is because suddenly a lot of films got bunched up. *Pushpa*, *RRR*, *KGF*, *Vikram*, etc., released in quick succession. Our business is of hits and misses. In the Hindi [film industry], what has happened is that some of the films that were expected to do well have underwhelmed. But we’re hopeful that this is going to be one of the best years for us, and going forward, there will be a lot of action in making Hindi films bigger in terms of production value,” he says.

All said and done, Bollywood producers are optimistic. “Cinema is a constantly evolving process, and the Bollywood industry is always progressing along with the changing times. Reinvention comes inherently to us. Currently, we see that films are tilting towards an OTT release purely because of budgets. Big-ticket films that are confident of their content, actors and crew, are going for theatrical releases,” says Bhushan Kumar, Chairman and MD of T-Series. His company has produced *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2*, one of the highest grossers of this year.

While there will be an audience for massy, upcoming big-budget movies in the theatres, there is a section of the